

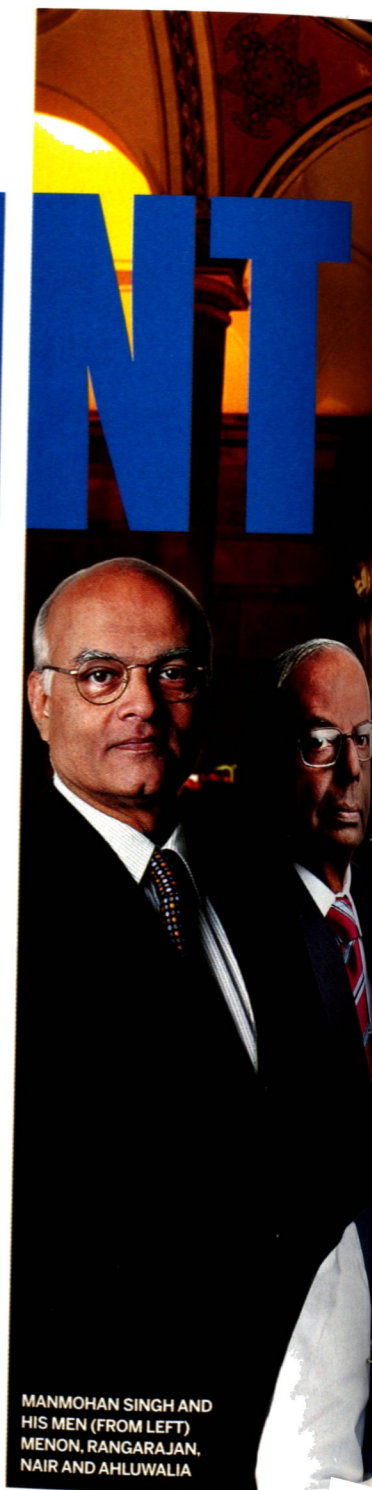
The Power POINT

The supremacy of the PMO in the Manmohan era brings out the evolutionary story of a shadowy institution that shapes the prime ministerial vision

| By Prabhu Chawla |

When Shyam Saran, a disgruntled insider, resigned from the post of Prime Minister's Special Envoy on Climate Change, it brought to the front pages the power struggle within the sanctum sanctorum of the executive power in the Republic: the Prime Minister's Office (PMO). Saran's agony was multipronged: a junior colleague with a higher rank; a high profile, articulate minister who refuses to play second fiddle to policy wonks with fancy designations; and the boss who let him down. So, the former foreign secretary and a key backroom brain behind the Indo-US nuclear deal, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's ticket to history, decided to leave the most hallowed part of South Block, overlooking the imposing grandeur of the Rashtrapati Bhavan. It is not the place from where any ambitious bureaucrat walks out willingly; it is the place one waits for a lifetime for an invitation to enter. The Prime Minister's Office is the nerve centre of power. It is here the first draft of the vision that defines a prime minister is prepared. It is the cabinet within the Central Cabinet and its mystique is further accentuated by its aura of secrecy—and a sense of unaccountability, if not infallibility.

Every PMO mirrors the personality of the incumbent prime minister—not only his priority as a policymaker but his fears, paranoia and, of course, his dream. Today, as the Age of Manmohan enters its second phase, it is a hyperactive PMO that shapes the defining agendas of this Government—or the abiding



MANMOHAN SINGH AND HIS MEN (FROM LEFT) MENON, RANGARAJAN, NAIR AND AHLUWALIA